dating limits on independent spending by political committees); *Buckley*, 424 U. S., at 39–51 (striking down expenditure limits in 1971 Campaign Act). Relative availability of funds is after all a rough barometer of public support. The resources in the treasury of a business corporation, however, are not an indication of popular support for the corporation's political ideas. They reflect instead the economically motivated decisions of investors and customers. The availability of these resources may make a corporation a formidable political presence, even though the power of the corporation may be no reflection of the power of its ideas.

By requiring that corporate independent expenditures be financed through a political committee expressly established to engage in campaign spending, § 441b seeks to prevent this threat to the political marketplace. The resources available to *this* fund, as opposed to the corporate treasury, in fact reflect popular support for the political positions of the committee. *Pipefitters*, *supra*, acknowledged this objective of § 441b in noting the statement of Representative Hansen, its sponsor, that the "'underlying theory'" of this regulation "'is that substantial general purpose treasuries should not be diverted to political purposes,'" and that requiring funding by voluntary contributions would ensure that "'the money collected is that intended by those who contribute to be used for political purposes and not money diverted from another source.'" 407 U. S., at 423–424 (quoting 117 Cong. Rec. 43381 (1971)).[11] See also *Automobile Workers*, *supra*, at 582

[11] While business corporations may not represent the only organizations that pose this danger, they are by far the most prominent example of entities that enjoy legal advantages enhancing their ability to accumulate wealth. That Congress does not at present seek to regulate every possible type of firm fitting this description does not undermine its justification for regulating corporations. Rather, Congress' decision represents the "careful legislative adjustment of the federal electoral laws, in a 'cautious advance, step by step,'" to which we have said we owe considerable deference. *FEC* v. *National Right to Work Committee*, 459 U. S. 197, 209